

A JPP RESOURCE COLLECTION GUIDE

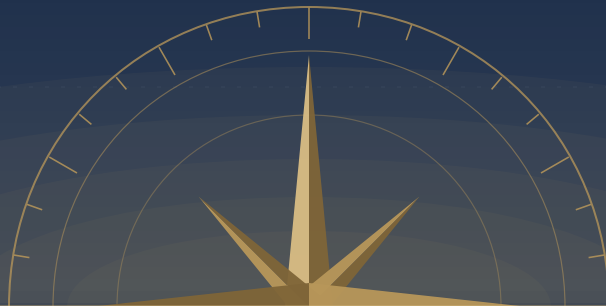
Beyond the Uniform

*A Military Life, Transition &
Family Reflection Guide*



SERVE · TRANSITION · CONNECT · CONTINUE

*For service members, veterans, military families,
and military-connected communities*



JACKRABBIT PUNKIN PUBLISHING LLC

STORIES THAT INSPIRE. BOOKS THAT ENDURE.

Service Is Never Only One Person's Story

Why this guide exists



When someone raises their hand to serve, the oath is theirs alone. The service that follows rarely is. A spouse learns to run a household across time zones. A child starts a new school for the third time in five years. A parent waits by the phone. Friendships stretch across duty stations, and routines are built, broken, and built again.

Then one day the uniform comes off, and a new question arrives: *who am I now, and who are we?*

This guide makes room for those stories. It is not a benefits checklist, a transition manual, or a form of treatment. It is a place to reflect, to put words to experiences that may never have had them, and to help the people who served together at home and in uniform understand one another a little better.

Who This Guide Is For

- Active-duty, Guard, and Reserve service members, and veterans of every branch and era
- Military spouses, partners, adult children, parents, and extended family
- Veterans' organizations, transition groups, chapels, and military-connected communities

What You Will Find Inside

Seven reflection sections, from the person you were before you served to the life you are building now. Family pages and a side-by-side conversation exercise. A shared Service Timeline, a letter you never have to send, a guide for groups, and a final worksheet called My Next Watch.

Service may end. Life, and the story, continue.

Barbara J. Ratliff

Co-Founder & CEO, Jackrabbit Punkin Publishing LLC · U.S. Navy Veteran

How to Use This Guide

There is no wrong order and no required answer



On Your Own

Work through the pages that speak to you. Write in the margins, skip what isn't ready, and come back later.

As a Couple

Answer a section separately, then set aside unhurried time to talk about what each of you wrote.

As a Family

Use the Service Timeline and the family pages together. Older children and parents can add their own memories.

In a Group

Veterans' organizations, transition groups, and chapels can use the facilitator page to plan a session.

A Few Ground Rules

- **Every question is optional.** "I'd rather not answer that" is always a complete answer.
- **No ranking of sacrifice.** A deployment, a missed birthday, and a tenth move are all real. No one's experience cancels out anyone else's.
- **Listen to understand, not to fix.** When someone shares, the goal is to hear them, not to solve or correct their memory.
- **Honor every path.** Every branch, component, era, and specialty served. So did every family.

Take Care of Yourself

Reflection can bring up memories that feel heavier than expected. If that happens, it is fine to stop, take a walk, or talk with someone you trust. Support information for service members, veterans, and families is on the last page of this guide.

Our Service Timeline

Map the years together. Each person remembers different things.



Start with the day service began. Add duty stations, deployments, moves, births, graduations, losses, promotions, and the day the uniform came off. Leave the last column for what family members remember about that time.

YEAR	WHERE WE WERE	WHAT HAPPENED	WHAT THE FAMILY REMEMBERS

The Person Behind the Uniform

Before the rank, the rate, or the title, there was a person



1 Who were you before you raised your hand? What did you care about, and what did you hope for?

2 Why did you join, and has your answer changed over the years?

3 Who saw you off, and what do you remember about that day?

4 What part of who you were stayed with you the whole way through?

5 What would you want your family to know about the person you were at eighteen, or at the age you first put on the uniform?

What Service Asked of Us

An honest account of what was given, and what was gained



Service asks for time, distance, flexibility, and sometimes much more. It also gives: skills, friendships, purpose, and a way of seeing the world. Both columns belong to the same story.

WHAT SERVICE ASKED OF US	WHAT SERVICE GAVE US
<i>Example: Three Christmases apart</i>	<i>Example: Friends who became family</i>

What is one moment you missed that still matters to you?

What is one moment from service you would not trade for anything?

The Family Served Too

For spouses, partners, children, and parents



Families rarely receive medals, but they carry a great deal: the waiting, the moves, the solo decisions, and the courage to begin again somewhere new. These questions are for the people who served at home.

1 What did you learn to do on your own that you never expected to?

2 What was the hardest part of waiting, and what helped?

3 Which duty station or community felt most like home, and why?

4 What do you wish people outside military life understood?

For Younger Children

An adult can ask these aloud and write down the answers: What do you remember about when Mom or Dad was away? What is your favorite place we lived? What did we do to feel close when we were apart? What makes you proud of our family?

Separate Perspectives, Shared Story

Answer the same questions apart, then compare



The service member and a family member each answer privately, without looking. Then sit down together and read your answers side by side. You may find you remember the same season very differently, and both memories are true.

QUESTION	SERVICE MEMBER	FAMILY MEMBER
What was the hardest part of those years for you?		
What do you think was hardest for the other person?		
A moment you were proud of the other person		
Something you needed but didn't ask for		
What you want the two of you to remember		

Talking It Through

What to do once your answers are side by side



- 1 **Take turns reading.** Let each person read their own answer aloud without interruption.
- 2 **Start with curiosity.** "Tell me more about that" opens more doors than "That's not how it happened."
- 3 **Notice the surprises.** Where did you guess right about each other? Where were you completely wrong?
- 4 **Stop while it's still good.** One honest conversation is enough for one evening. You can always come back.

Words We Brought Home

Every military family picks up a language of its own. Record the phrases that followed you home, and what they mean in your house now.

PHRASE	WHAT IT MEANT IN SERVICE	WHAT IT MEANS AT HOME
<i>"Hurry up and wait"</i>	<i>Rush to be on time, then stand by</i>	<i>Every family road trip</i>

When the Uniform Comes Off

Separation, retirement, and the space in between



Leaving service changes more than a job. The structure of the day, the people around you, the way others see you, and sometimes the way you see yourself can all shift at once. Family members often feel that shift too. These questions are for everyone in the household.

What I Miss

What I Don't Miss

What Surprised Me

1 When someone asks "What do you do?" what do you wish you could tell them?

2 Where do you find the sense of belonging your unit, ship, or command once gave you?

3 What habit from service do you still keep, and which one are you glad to let go?

To _____,

Reconnecting After Separation or Retirement

Coming home is a season, not a single day



Whether the time apart was a deployment, a long training cycle, or years of irregular hours, reconnecting takes patience. Roles shifted while you were apart. Children grew, routines changed, and everyone learned to cope in their own way. None of that has to be undone. It can be blended.

Our Reconnection Plan

Something that worked while we were apart that we want to keep

Something we want to change or share differently now

A new tradition we would like to start

How we will check in with each other, and how often

One thing each of us needs the others to know right now

What I Carried Forward

The strengths, values, and keepsakes that came home with you



Strengths I Still Use

- | | | |
|---|--|--|
| ☐ Discipline | ☐ Adaptability | ☐ Leadership |
| ☐ Teamwork | ☐ Calm under pressure | ☐ Attention to detail |
| ☐ Resilience | ☐ Loyalty | ☐ Resourcefulness |
| ☐ Keeping my word | ☐ Sense of humor | ☐ Faith |
| ☐ Showing up early | ☐ Mission focus | ☐ Other: _____ |

An Object That Came Home With Me

A challenge coin, a cover, a letter, a photograph, a folded flag, a set of orders, a small keepsake from a place far away. What is it, and what story does it hold?

A saying or piece of advice from service I still repeat

A value from service I hope my family carries after me

What I Choose Not to Carry Forward

Not everything from one season has to travel into the next. A habit, expectation, role, or burden I am ready to reconsider:

Using This Guide With a Group

For veterans' organizations, transition groups, chapels, and family groups



A Sample 75-Minute Session

TIME	ACTIVITY
10 min	Welcome, introductions, and the ground rules on page 3
15 min	Opening round: "Where and when did you serve, or serve alongside someone?"
20 min	Quiet writing on one section chosen for the session
20 min	Voluntary sharing in pairs or small groups
10 min	Closing with one question from My Next Watch

Keep in Mind

- **Mixed groups work well.** Veterans and family members often learn the most from hearing each other's side of the same experience.
- **Never ask for combat details.** Let people decide what to share and how much. Silence is participation too.
- **Welcome every component and era.** Active, Guard, Reserve, every branch including the Coast Guard and Space Force, and families of all kinds.
- **Have support information ready.** Keep the last page of this guide on hand, and know who to contact if someone needs more than the group can offer.
- **Faith-based groups** may open or close with prayer or scripture as fits their tradition.

Planning a Six-Meeting Series

Meeting 1	The Person Behind the Uniform	Meeting 4	When the Uniform Comes Off
Meeting 2	What Service Asked of Us	Meeting 5	What I Carried Forward
Meeting 3	The Family Served Too	Meeting 6	My Next Watch

My Next Watch

Service may end. Life certainly doesn't.



What am I carrying forward?

What am I ready to put down?

Who is part of this next chapter?

What does service look like for me now?

What do I want the people I love to understand?

Beyond the uniform, I am

NAME

WATCH SET

THE WATCH CONTINUES

Beyond the Uniform



The uniform may hang in a closet now. The person who wore it, and the family who stood beside them, are still writing the story.

Thank you for your service, in uniform and at home. May the next chapter be as meaningful as the ones behind you.

Serve · Transition · Connect · Continue

Keep Learning

Find more complimentary guides, activities, and educational materials in the JPP Resource Center.

[[Resource Center link](#)]

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If you or someone you love needs support now: the Veterans/Military Crisis Line serves veterans, service members, and their families and friends, 24 hours a day. In the U.S., dial 988, then press 1; text 838255; or chat online at VeteransCrisisLine.net. Service members overseas can find local numbers on the same site. In an emergency, call 911.

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